

LOCAL NEWS MARCH 23, 2012

Library's Food for Fines program is a win-win



LIBRARY COLUMN

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George Williams Associated Press

To many patrons at all branches of Latah County Library, springtime offers something special to look forward to: The two-week Food for Fines campaign.

This year, Food for Fines will take place April 15-28. Coinciding with it is another reason to be excited, as we are migrating to a new library software system. The library district's new catalog system, Koha, will go into effect April 23.

Back to Food for Fines, between April 15 and 28, if you have late fees on any library materials owned by the Latah County Library District, you can pay those fees by bringing nonperishable food items to any of the seven Latah County library branches. Fees will be forgiven at the rate of \$1 in fees for every nonperishable food item.

All of the food collected will go to local food banks. Food will only be accepted for the payment of late fees. If you have fees for lost or damaged items, you can't pay them with food.

We run Food for Fines every year for a couple of reasons. Patrons with late fees on their library accounts are blocked from using some of the online services offered through the catalog. They can't use their account to renew their checkouts or to place holds.

For some patrons, food donations are more manageable than cash. Paying off their late fees with food will enable them to use their account again. It's a win for

us and a win for them.

It's also a win for our communities, which is the most important reason we run the campaign. The Latah County Library District operates libraries in Bovill, Deary, Genesee, Juliaetta, Moscow, Potlatch and Troy. In the last four years, our Food for Fines campaigns have collected more than 3,000 pounds of food for food banks in these communities. Just as last year, our local food banks need help because of a continuing flat economy.

So please come in to your local library during our Food for Fines campaign and help your community by bringing in food for your local food bank. If you have late fees, we'll be happy to forgive them. If you don't have late fees, we'll still accept any food you'd like to contribute.

Also help us celebrate our new software system, Koha, which will "go live" April 23. If you have questions about Koha, we'll be running a column with more details in a couple of weeks. And if you're confused about the pronunciation, Koha rhymes with aloha.

George Williams is the access services manager for Latah County Library.

STORY TAGS

Food

